

Film Archiver

A desktop application for building a structured, searchable film photography archive. Film Archiver bridges your digital scans with physical negative storage through a thoughtful naming system and rich metadata embedding.

The Archive Philosophy

Film Archiver creates a **dual-layer organization system** designed to work independently yet complement each other:

Layer 1: Finder-Based Archive

Your film scans live in a structured folder hierarchy that you control—completely independent from any photo management software. This gives you:

- Direct access via Finder/file browser
- Easy backup and portability
- Quick visual navigation by year/roll
- No lock-in to any specific application

Layer 2: Metadata Integration

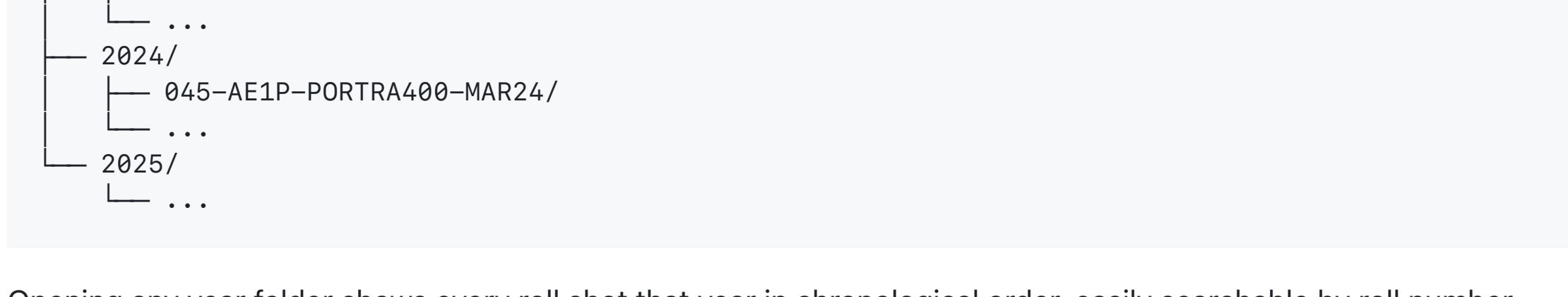
EXIF metadata embedded in each file enables seamless integration with photo management apps (Lightroom, Capture One, Photo Mechanic, etc.):

- **Date metadata** keeps files chronologically organized in catalogs
- **Lens metadata** enables filtering and searching by lens
- Import into any DAM software and maintain organization automatically

Recommended Practice: Store your Film Archive folder separately from where your photo management app stores its managed files. This keeps your master archive navigable in Finder while still accessible to catalog software.

Recommended Folder Structure

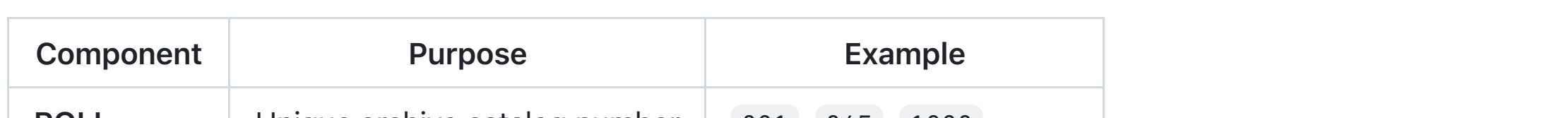
Set up a master archive folder with subfolders organized by year:



Opening any year folder shows every roll shot that year in chronological order, easily searchable by roll number, camera, or film stock.

The Naming Format

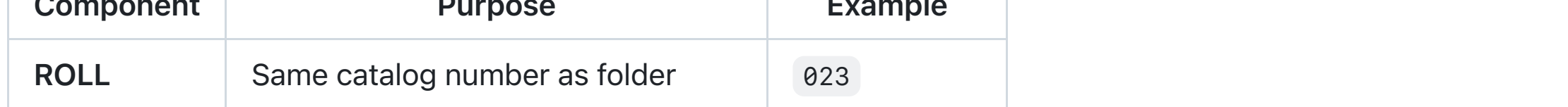
Folder Naming



Component	Purpose	Example
ROLL	Unique archive catalog number	001 , 045 , 1000
CAMERA	Camera body used	CLE , AE1P , M6
STOCK	Film stock	400D , HP5 , PORTRA400
MONTH+YR	When the roll was shot	JAN23 , MAR24 , NOV25

Example: 023-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400-NOV25

File Naming



Component	Purpose	Example
ROLL	Same catalog number as folder	023
FRAME	Frame number within roll	01 , 15 , 36
CAMERA	Camera body (redundant for safety)	CANON_AE1P
STOCK	Film stock (redundant for safety)	PORTRA400

Example: 023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400.jpg

Optional Suffixes

For push/pull processing or shooting at a different ISO:

Situation	Suffix	Example Filename
Pushed +1	(+1)	023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400(+1).jpg
Pulled -1	(-1)	023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400(-1).jpg
Shot at ISO 800	(@800)	023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400(@800).jpg

Why Duplicate Names Are Impossible

The naming scheme is designed so that **every file has a globally unique name**, even if files accidentally get moved to wrong folders:

1. **Roll number is unique** across your entire archive (you never reuse a roll number)
2. **Frame number is unique** within each roll (01-36 typically)
3. The combination of `ROLL-FRAME` creates a unique identifier that can never collide

Even if you moved `023-15-CANON_AE1P-PORTRA400.jpg` into the folder for roll 045, the filename itself contains roll 023 so there's no ambiguity about which negative it came from.

Dynamic Roll Numbering

Film Archiver automatically adjusts padding based on your archive size:

Archive Size	Padding	Examples
Rolls 1-999	3 digits	001 , 023 , 999
Rolls 1000+	4+ digits	1000 , 1234 , 5432

This ensures proper alphabetical sorting regardless of how large your archive grows.

Metadata Benefits

EXIF Date Embedding

Film Archiver sets these date fields in each file:

- `DateTimeOriginal` — when the photo was taken
- `DateTimeDigitized` — synced to the same date
- `DateTime` — file modification date
- macOS creation date (on Mac)

Result: Import files into any photo management app and they automatically sort chronologically, regardless of when they were scanned.

Lens Metadata

Store the lens used for each frame in the EXIF `LensModel` field:

- Filter photos by lens in your catalog software
- Track which lenses you use most
- Apply different lenses to individual frames within a roll

Cross-Referencing Physical ↔ Digital

The roll number is your **universal catalog ID** linking digital files to physical negatives.

Finding the Negative for a Digital File

1. Note the roll number from the filename (e.g., `023-15-...` → Roll 023)
2. Find physical negative sleeve labeled `023`
3. Locate frame 15 on the sleeve

Finding Digital Files for a Physical Negative

1. Note the roll number on the sleeve (e.g., `023`)
2. In Finder: search for `023-` in your Film Archive
3. In your photo app: filter by filename containing `023-`

Features

- **Image preview** with thumbnail caching
- **Favorites** for cameras, films, and lenses
- **Per-file lens assignment** for rolls shot with multiple lenses
- **Reverse file order** toggle (labs often scan in reverse)
- **Date picker** with calendar widget
- **Push/Pull notation** or custom shot-at ISO
- **Dark mode** support (follows macOS system setting)
- **RAW format support** (CR2, CR3, NEF, ARW, DNG, etc.)
- **Auto-increment roll number** after processing for streamlined multi-roll workflow
- **Smart destination memory** — folder picker opens to the parent of last used location
- **Bug report & feature request** — submit feedback directly from the Help menu

System Requirements

macOS Compatibility

Film Archiver is built for macOS and supports a wide range of versions:

macOS Version	Support Status	Notes
10.13 High Sierra	✔ Supported	Light theme only (no system dark mode)
10.14 Mojave	✔ Supported	Full functionality including dark mode
10.15 Catalina	✔ Supported	Full functionality
11.0 Big Sur	✔ Supported	Full functionality
12.0 Monterey	✔ Supported	Full functionality (Intel & Apple Silicon)
13.0 Ventura	✔ Supported	Full functionality
14.0 Sonoma	✔ Supported	Full functionality
15.0 Sequoia	✔ Supported	Full functionality

Architecture Support:

- ✔ Intel Macs (x64)
- ✔ Apple Silicon Macs (M1/M2/M3/M4 - ARM64)

Known Limitations

Drag and Drop: In the packaged DMG version, drag-and-drop is disabled due to compatibility issues with the bundled runtime. Use the **Add Files** button to select images instead. This does not affect any other functionality.

Dark Mode: Automatic dark mode detection requires macOS 10.14 Mojave or later. On older versions, the app will use the light theme.

Gatekeeper Notice

Since Film Archiver is not yet notarized with Apple, macOS may display a security warning on first launch. To open the app:

1. **Right-click** (or Control-click) on Film Archiver in Applications
2. Select **Open** from the context menu
3. Click **Open** in the dialog that appears

You only need to do this once—subsequent launches will work normally.

Alternatively: System Preferences → Security & Privacy → General → click "Open Anyway"

Getting Started

See the detailed [Installation & Usage Guide](#) in the app directory.

Quick Start:

1. Download the latest `.dmg` from [Releases](#)
2. Drag Film Archiver to Applications
3. Add your scanned files
4. Fill in roll number, camera, film, and date
5. Click **Process Files** and choose your output folder

Version

Current version: 1.2.4

See [Changelog](#) for release history.

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